because not only did the agitators approach the pensioners, they also approached the Sikh regiments, and at Ferozepur several hundred sepoys ‘attended a most seditious meeting to which they had been specially invited’. The developing situation, of ‘a campaign of sedition’ was viewed so seriously that it ‘was described by the Lieutenant-Governor at the end of April, 1907, as exceedingly serious, exceedingly dangerous, and urgently demanding a remedy’. [6] If this is how the lieutenant-governor felt, he had good reason to do so.

A retired postal officer by the name of Sifaj-ud Din Ahmed had in 1903 established a newspaper, appropriately called the *Zamindar*, to vent the frustrations of colonists like Bhagat Singh’s grandfather, Sardar Arjan Singh, who had migrated from Katkhar Kalyan in Jalandhar District to the canal area where they settled at Banga village, in Lyallpur. If anyone understood the problems of the yeoman farmers, it would be people like Bhagat Singh’s uncle, Ajit Singh. His time would come before long. Simmering discontent would not take long to turn into outright political opposition. When the *Zamindar* held a public meeting on 22 and 23 March 1907 to demonstrate against the The Punjab Colonisation of Land Bill of 1906, Ajit Singh made haste to find ways of opposing it. He despatched delegates from the Bharat Mata Society to campaign against the coming into law of the bill. Lala Lajpat Rai was asked by the *Zamindar* to address the yeomanry. As he left for Lyallpur, he sent a communique to Ajit Singh in which he intimated that there should be an expression of gratitude from the podium for the government having agreed to a previous amendment, before a demand was made for the repeal of the bill. Ajit Singh disagreed. He wanted to prepare the masses for a no-revenue campaign and did not want to have a record of thanks being given. The two differed on tactics. This was reflected in the manner in which they both spoke at the meeting of 22 and 23 March 1907 in Lyallpur, with Lala Lajpat Rai being conciliatory and Ajit Singh being defiant.

This is how the 1907 disturbances in the Canal Colonies occurred, and they shook the colonial state to its roots. Suddenly, the idea of the unshakeable loyalty of the Punjab rural peasantry was broken. Initially,